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The constitution of school autonomy in Australian public education: areas of paradox for social justice

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ABSTRACT

School autonomy policies have circulated through various modes of educational governance internationally, endorsing the view that more autonomy will improve schools and their systems. When subject to the discourses and practices of marketization, however, school 'autonomy' has been mobilized in ways that generate injustice. These injustices are the focus of this paper. We draw on preliminary findings from a three-year study that is exploring the social justice implications of school autonomy reform across four Australian states. Drawing on interviews with 42 stakeholders, the paper identifies four key areas of paradox for social justice currently confronting public schools and school systems. The language of paradox is drawn on to narrate the oppositional politics between the discourses and practices constituting school autonomy and the pursuit of social justice. Such narration raises important questions for Australian public education. It highlights how these discourses are changing what is meant by the public in public education. Engaging with the language of paradox in thinking about school autonomy reform, we argue, is important given the broader landscape where public schooling is being reconstituted and where traditional links to social justice and the common good are under threat.

School autonomy reform and social justice

With various articulations across local and global education contexts, the common intention of school autonomy reform is to free public schools from centralized authority to better respond to local needs and drive up educational standards. There remains little conclusive evidence to support the efficacy of this reform to improve schools and their systems. Indeed, greater school autonomy in contexts such as England, the US, Sweden, Norway and Australia is associated with producing further inequalities as it has coincided with an increasing marketization of education and the discourses and practices of economic efficiency, competition, individualism and externally imposed accountability.

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School autonomy policies, as they are located within and shaped by neoliberal reforms, do not fulfill their promise of improving student learning outcomes and indeed compromise social justice at the school and system levels (see Ball & Junemann, 2012; Keddie, 2017). This paper explores the issue of school autonomy reform and social justice in the Australian context. Drawing on interviews with 42 education stakeholders, the paper identifies four key areas of paradox for social justice currently confronting public schools and their systems. The language of paradox is drawn on to narrate the oppositional politics between the discourses constituting school autonomy and the pursuit of social justice. Such narration raises important questions for Australian public education. It highlights how these discourses are changing what is meant by the *public* in public education. Engaging with the language of paradox in thinking about school autonomy reform, we argue, is important given the broader landscape where public schooling is being reconstituted and its traditional links to social justice and the common good are under threat.

The Australian case

The particularities of the Australian education context (as distinct from other western education systems) are important to explain in understanding the policy debates over school autonomy and funding equity. Australian schooling has three sectors with six states and two territory public education systems (comprising of 65.7% of all students), the Catholic sector (comprising 19.5%), and the independent sector, ranging from predominantly faith-based small to large elite schools (comprising 14.8% of all students; Australian Curriculum Assessment and Reporting Authority, 2020). Public schools are state responsibilities, with private and Catholic schools first receiving federal funding from the 1960s. Federal funding to non-government (i.e. Catholic and private) schools based on need was extended in the mid-1970s with the aim to sustain equitable provision for a declining Catholic sector. But a neoliberal and socially conservative federal government changed the rules after 2000, funding non-government schools based on postcode, which meant wealthy schools in close proximity to less well-off government schools received increased government funding and new small private schools gained funding to establish themselves where often government schools had closed (Morgan & Blackmore, 2013). In order to maintain a cost-neutral policy, the federal government also withdrew per capita funding from state governments that was to be allocated to fund government schools. With parental choice discourses being mobilized by federal and some state governments, many families able to afford choice moved their children into the non-government sector fueling the expansion of elite and particularly small faith-based schools, thus residualizing the public sector. While private schools now receive federal funding, they are not obligated to enroll all applicants whereas government schools must enroll students in their zone, and now teach over 85% of the students who are disadvantaged (Cobbold, 2020).

Recent equity-policy funding at state and federal levels (e.g. Gonski funding) (Gonski et al., 2018, 2011) has attempted to redistribute resources more equitably across the public and private systems. There remains, however, marked levels of maldistribution especially given the differential capacities of individual schools to accrue resources from

their communities and other sources (e.g. business, philanthropy and parent fundraising; Hogan & Thompson, 2019; Rowe & Perry, 2019b; Thompson et al., 2019).

Policies of school autonomy reform in Australia are set against this complex and inequitable backdrop. The intentions and guidelines of this reform have shifted from their original promotion in the 'Karmel Report' (Karmel et al., 1973) as a grassroots, bottom-up reform drawing on notions of participatory democracy to today's national and state versions of, for example, Independent Public Schools (IPS), which draw on neoliberal notions of greater efficiency and accountability. Amid these shifts, state articulations of school autonomy reform have differed markedly. States like Victoria (Vic) have experienced a long and complex history of devolution since the early 1990s while other states such as New South Wales (NSW) have (until quite recently) remained highly centralized. There has been a renewed focus in Australia on creating more autonomy within public school systems with the conservative federal government in 2015 committing 70 AUDmillion to 'build on current developments across the states to help schools become more autonomous and independent if they so choose' (Australian Government, 2016). The implementation of the IPS policy in Western Australia (WA) reflects perhaps the most recent radical restructuring of that state's public education system with the conversion of 575 schools to IPS status (Department of Education, 2019).

While mobilized in highly varied ways, the common thrust of this policy is similarly framed – to grant schools greater freedom in governance and decision-making so they can better respond to the local needs of their communities. The belief here (as with similar reforms in other western countries such as England, the USA, Norway and Sweden) is that such freedoms will encourage innovation and efficiency and will lead to school improvement (Cobbold, 2014; Gobby, 2013; Wilkinson et al., 2018). This reform provides school leaders with greater power and discretion over their budget and their decision-making capacity in relation to staffing, resourcing and programs. Equity funds from national and state governments, based on student profiles, needs, and since 2002 location according to postcode, are additional loadings for school leaders to manage. The questions that are yet to be settled in these reforms include what matters when it comes to school autonomy and with what effect in terms of social justice outcomes for each school and student within the system-wide public provision.

Counter to its policy intentions, school autonomy reform across the globe, e.g. England's academies, Charter Schools in Sweden or the USA or self-governing schools in New Zealand, has not led to school 'improvement' as measured by student academic attainment (Academies Commission, 2013; Darling-Hammond & Montgomery, 2008; Gunter, 2012; Ministry of Education NZ, 2018; Ravitch, 2016). In Australia, similarly, there is no evidence linking school autonomy reform unilaterally with a rise in student attainment (Jensen et al., 2013; Melbourne Graduate School of Education, 2013; Smyth, 2011). In terms of social justice and, in particular, redistributive justice (e.g. a more equitable allocation of human and material resources for students (Fraser, 2009), the impacts of this reform are mixed. There is some evidence to indicate that increased flexibility in relation to school funding has led, in some cases, to a more equitable distribution of material and human resources for marginalized or disadvantaged students; and that such flexibility can lead to a more efficient use of these resources than might have been previously possible under more centralized governance (Bandaranayake, 2013; Holloway & Keddie, 2018; Keddie, 2015).

Generally, however, the market imperatives of economic efficiency, competition and external auditing driving school 'autonomy' are seen as producing negative impacts for redistributive justice. The imperatives of economic rationalism accompanying this reform have tended to decimate the structures, resources and programs of central education bureaucracies traditionally associated with supporting public schools. These imperatives have whittled away support for schools and their leaders to manage ever-increasing obligations and responsibilities previously the domain of the state (Ball & Junemann, 2012; Smyth, 2011). While most principals have welcomed the greater autonomy over decision-making for their schools granted to them under this reform, the work intensities and responsibilities for school leaders have become untenable in devolved education systems. Such work intensities have led to high levels of stress and have diverted principals' attention away from instructional leadership (Niesche & Thomson, 2017; Thomson, 2010).

To survive within this environment of decreased funding and the pressures of economic efficiency, many schools are turning to parent and local community fundraising (Rowe & Perry 2019a), and the philanthropic and corporate sectors to meet shortfalls. Indeed, entrepreneurial connections with this sector have been encouraged in school autonomy policy in some states such as Victoria (Department of Education and Early Childhood Development, 2019). These non-state actors, many for profit, are moving into schools to mitigate the absence of the state through providing crucial resources (e.g. capital funding, human and material resources). However, as well recognized, their intentions and goals (profit) can undermine educative and social goals given these organizations may tend to prioritize economic gains (Blackmore, 2011; Holloway & Keddie, 2018; Lingard et al., 2017). Further negative impacts for redistributive justice are associated with the lack of regulation and transparency within devolved education systems over how resources are accrued and expended (Wilkinson et al., 2018). This lack of oversight is attributed to a rise in the misuse of funds and corrupt practices such as has occurred in corruption uncovered in Victoria (Independent Broad-based Anti-corruption Commission, 2017).

One of the key platforms of school autonomy reform is the notion of 'choice'. Providing parents and students with choice generally means enabling them to compare and select schools on the basis of their academic performance on standardized tests. This information has become freely available to the public through websites such as MySchool which publishes individual school results based on NAPLAN standardized testing and post-school outcomes. This is an economic supply and demand model with expectations that it will drive up standards, as it assumes failing schools (i.e. those that do poorly on standardized tests) with reducing parental demand will close while succeeding schools will flourish. This market – accountability model has increased stratification and residualization within the public system through valuing (publicly rewarding) and de-valuing (publicly shaming) schools on the basis of their academic test performance (Doolan & Blackmore, 2018; Lamb et al., 2015). The equity implications of this stratification are particularly pronounced in under-resourced schools (e.g. small schools, schools in remote or rural areas). Further compounding this stratification is the relationship between a school's positioning (e.g. location, social mix, level of disadvantage) and its capacity to attract and maintain quality teachers (Mayer et al., 2017). Rural/remote schools and schools in highly disadvantaged locations are difficult to staff (Sullivan

et al., 2013). Such competition has undermined school collaboration and increased ‘gaming’ practices where schools ‘recruit more selectively and exclude more willingly’ (Windle, 2015, p. 24) in order to prevent reputational damage (Morgan & Blackmore, 2013). It has also narrowed curriculum and pedagogy in the least advantaged schools to a teach-to-the-test mentality (Blackmore, 2016; Heffernan, 2018; Lingard & Sellar, 2012).

These discourses of devolution, economic efficiency, competition and individualism shaping public education in Australia call into question what is public about public education. Such discourses have encouraged practices which have increasingly privatized the sector (see Blackmore, 2011; Gobby, 2018) and rendered unstable the political claim of education as a common good (in terms of its deep tradition to democratic participation and active informed citizenship; see Boyask, 2020; Gerrard, 2018; Smyth, 2011). Such instability points to the constantly changing understandings and practices of public education – ‘the ‘public’ is ‘incessantly shifting – and historically mediated’ (Gerrard, 2018, p. 208; and see Boyask, 2020).

Amid this shifting terrain, we examine key areas of paradox for social justice currently confronting public schools and school systems in Australia as relayed to us by a group of education stakeholders across four states: Victoria, Queensland, Western Australia and New South Wales. We use the language of paradox to help narrate the oppositional politics (Dolan, 2020) between the discourses shaping school autonomy and the pursuit of social justice as it relates to the redistribution of material and human resources (see Fraser, 2009). These areas of paradox are:

- (1) The discourses and practices of economic efficiency and differential funding (between the public and private sectors) constitute school ‘autonomy’ in ways that create economic injustice
- (2) The discourses and practices of competition and individualism shaping education systems constitute school autonomy in ways that undermine equity at the system level
- (3) The discourses and practices of devolution and economic rationalism shaping the public education system constitute school autonomy in ways that disadvantage (already disadvantaged) schools
- (4) The discourses and practices of needs-based funding (when reflecting a lack of transparency, nuance and administrative support) constitute school autonomy in ways that create economic injustice

Research context and processes

The data presented in this paper derive from a broader three-year Australian Research Council study that is exploring the social justice implications of school autonomy reform across four states in Australia: Queensland (QLD), Victoria (Vic), Western Australia (WA) and New South Wales (NSW). These four states were selected given their highly varied histories and enactments of school autonomy reform. The study is examining how school autonomy is understood by key education stakeholders in Australia; how it is enacted in Australian public schools; and the implications of this enactment for social justice. In this paper, we present findings from the first year of the study from interviews with 42 stakeholders including representatives from educational bureaucracies (12);

government (3); parent organizations (3); principal associations (7); principals (4); professional organizations (3); academia (4) and teacher unions (6). These stakeholders represent: Victoria (14); NSW (8); Qld (8); and WA (10) with two stakeholders representing national associations or viewpoints. Stakeholders were selected on the basis of their leadership within their respective organizations/associations and on their extensive knowledge about, and experience of, school autonomy reform. In referring to these stakeholders in the following sections, we identify the state they are associated with and their relationship to education, but de-identify with pseudonyms.

The interviews were conducted over several months in 2019 by the team (of seven researchers). All interviews (usually 60–90 minutes long) involved two researchers to maintain consistency and one, or sometimes two, interviewees and were conducted either face-to-face or online. The interviews were focused on exploring the participants' understandings of school autonomy including the origins and development of this idea in Australia; the renewed focus nationally and internationally on school autonomy reform; the impacts of this reform at the school and system levels in terms of social justice (e.g. in relation to decision-making, the allocation of resources and differential benefits regarding student outcomes, leadership practices and teachers' work); important factors for mobilizing school autonomy in productive ways; and the role of regional support in autonomous systems.

The data were organized using Nvivo. Coding was driven by our research aims and, in particular, the concepts highlighted in the interview questions noted above. This paper focuses on analysis of the themes of 'social justice' and 'equity' which broadly included all stakeholder comments about these two concepts. Our analysis deployed the language of paradox to help narrate the oppositional politics between the discourses and practices shaping school autonomy and the pursuit of social justice as it relates to the redistribution of material and human resources (Dolan, 2020). This process involved firstly, identifying these discourses and practices as expressed by the stakeholders and secondly, the social justice implications of these discourses and practices. Our understandings of paradox drew on the work of Dolan (2020) as 'formed out of the constitutive practices of discourses rather than functioning as representations of conflict or complexity' (p. 5). Thus, the areas of paradox we present do not reflect the symmetry and pragmatism of a two-sided conflict but an array of 'competing discourses, marked by variations across space and time, differential interminglings with local practice and asymmetrical levels of prominence and influence' (p. 5). Like Dolan (2020, p. 5), our analysis seeks to 'problematize and make vulnerable the discourses that dominate contemporary schooling and to reveal, through the formulation of various paradoxes, the competing interests that shape and influence' the take up of school autonomy.

Paradox 1: the discourses and practices of economic efficiency and differential funding (between the public and private sectors) constitute school 'autonomy' in ways that create economic injustice

Interviewees commented on the ways in which school autonomy was not really 'autonomy' at all. As teacher union official Lucas (Qld) noted, autonomy cannot be considered without understanding the 'frame' within which it is situated, 'We actually need to consider the legislation policies, procedures, curriculum; all of those things [that] form

the barrier – the boundary; and then autonomy occurs within that’. Many stakeholders were highly cognizant and critical of the inequities of this ‘frame’ created by the processes of marketization and devolution. Academic Quincy (National), for example, highlighted how the system had shifted from a democratic to an economic efficiency discourse. The economic efficiency discourse framing devolution or school autonomy reform at both national and state levels was a dominant concern for many of the stakeholders as significantly creating maldistribution within and across education systems. Edward, a teacher union official, for example, commenting about school autonomy reform in NSW, stated:

Local Schools, Local Decisions had nothing to do with parental choice or freeing up schools or any of that political overlay. It was the device where they could get cost efficiency and draw down cost [to] almost all areas of school operations ... [it was about] how we could save money ...

Delia (teacher union, Vic) commented on how the economic efficiency discourse had taken on material effects as it worked to decimate the public education sector through decreasing regional and departmental support. She noted that the budget cuts to middle levels of bureaucratic management ‘under the guise of autonomy and devolution’ as currently reflected in WA (and mirroring earlier trends in Victoria) left schools ‘bereft of the critical advice and support that they need to deal with a whole range of equity issues’. Such cuts were, as we examine later, seen to disadvantage particular (under-resourced) schools and exacerbate stratification and residualization within the system. In Uberta’s words (bureaucrat, Vic), it was really difficult for schools to ‘break out’ of their positioning at the low end of the hierarchy, as she further explained:

... it’s a ‘vicious cycle’ ... if the school doesn’t have that reputation, then teachers don’t want to teach there; so, all of a sudden, the best and brightest teaching staff obviously aren’t the ones that are going to be attracted to go and teach at that school. So, of course, that will have a huge impact on academic outcomes. And then if the academic outcomes of the school aren’t great, then no-one wants to send their kids there.

Charles (principal, Vic) expressed particular concern about the funding differential between private and public schools across Australia. As we noted earlier, Australia has, compared to other Western nations, a particularly large non-government school sector (Catholic and private) funded federally by the taxpayer, educating around 35% of all students. Charles described funding to the private sector as creating a ‘facilities arms race’ for private schools able to build and re-build ‘staggering’ facilities ‘because they can, while many schools within the public system (especially in low SES areas) languished as they tried to ‘wring every cent’ out of their allocated per student state funding. This assemblage of differential funding produces maldistribution (i.e. inequitable funding within and across sectors). Combined with the market drivers of economic efficiency and competition, goals of fairness are severely undermined (Blackmore, 2011; Gobby, 2018; Keddie, 2017; Smyth, 2011).

In sum, a variety of stakeholders reported that the discourses and practices of economic efficiency and differential funding (between the public and private sectors) constitute school autonomy in ways that create economic injustice; they have decimated

the public education sector, exacerbated stratification and residualization within this sector and exacerbated economic disparity between public and private sectors.

Paradox 2: the discourses and practices of competition and individualism shaping education systems constitute school autonomy in ways that undermine equity at the system level

As noted in the previous section, respondents generally agreed that ‘there’s no true autonomy’ because, as Jack (professional organization, WA) noted, we ‘sit’ within ‘a system’. For Jack ‘autonomy’, which he defined as ‘putting decision-making at the closest level possible’ to the school, was preferred as long as it did not ‘impinge on another school’, thereby imparting a sense of obligation to the public system. The imperatives driving competition within and between public and private sectors, however, necessarily impinged on other schools, such as ‘poaching’ staff from nearby schools, or encouraging ‘failing’ students to change schools, contributing to residualization. Many stakeholders across all states expressed the view that school autonomy could create equity at the local level through ‘localised decisions based on the needs of your community’ (professional organization, Belinda, Vic). But schools do not operate in isolation. The success of one school can compromise equity system-wide because the choices of one school may limit options for others nearby. Cedric (professional organization, Vic) explained that this was because school autonomy was:

... based on the notion that each individual school is responsible for the education of its students, not the system ... It is not just one school operating irrespective of what’s happening around them ... and the idea that competition between schools is going to raise standards, it just doesn’t ...

Many stakeholders noted the significance of a collective approach to education as a public good, as Louise (parent organization, WA) stated, schools ‘should be working together for the benefit of all students for equity; not equality, for equity’. Many were critical of how competition and economic efficiency undermined this collective approach to education as a public good. Uhlrich (bureaucrat, Vic), for example, suggested that the devolution seen in the Victorian system has led to the tendency for schools ‘to be more isolationist; and they tend to think only about what their role within the school is. So there’s less system-based thinking’. Delia (teacher union, Vic) referred to Victoria’s history of devolution as a case in point following the ‘rampant competition’ introduced in the ‘Kennett [conservative state political leader] years’ in the 1990s where the ‘model of funding was changed to a student-numbered system ... so the more students you have, the more funding you get’. Cedric (professional organization, Vic) agreed, ‘the more students you get, the more money you have. And to be frank, the bigger you are, the better economies of scale you have under the global budget model’. Delia further commented:

Throw in school choice which we have in Victoria – I think, unfortunately – where you can bypass your local school and go to whatever school you like, providing they have got room, that [has] meant that schools have openly competed for students. They know it will deliver more money. When you come to the issue of equity, that has just simply created a much greater divide.

Travis (bureaucrat, Vic) described these processes as creating ‘goal displacement in the system’ where principals are compelled to focus on maximizing their school rather than the system. Such processes, he added, were encouraged by how principals were valued – i.e. as principals who could ‘turn around struggling schools’, not as system contributors.

A key concern expressed by stakeholders regarding this goal displacement related to student enrollment exclusion. Cedric (professional organization, Vic) explained that this was about ‘unloading your problems on somebody else’ because ‘you want to appear better than the other schools down the road’. For Charles (principal, Vic) this ‘unloading’ was prevalent and ultimately associated with funding, as he stated:

... if you get funded by the amount of students or bums on seats, if you get a kid who you think is going to cost you enrolments ... the shutters come down and they go, ‘If I bring this kid in my school, he/she will do XYZ. I don’t want a bar of them’.

While schools wanted to be ‘bigger’ given the funding and the economies of scale size accrued, many actively rejected ‘problem’ students. Certainly exclusionary practices associated with student enrollment pre-date school autonomy reform, but many of the stakeholders viewed these practices as more prevalent given the freedoms of this reform (Keddie, 2015). Lucas (teacher union, Qld) for example, noted how school autonomy reform in Qld led to a belief in some Independent Public (IP) schools that ‘they had the authority to alter their enrolment processes’ to exclude particular students (e.g. Indigenous students, refugees and students with a disability). While counter to the ‘fundamental requirement of our Education Act, that state schools accept the student that turns up at the gate’, there was, as he explained, ‘clear evidence’ that some IP schools were ‘turning away students’, suggesting to parents that ‘perhaps that student would be better off at another school because our school can’t provide them with the program that would be best suited to their needs’.

In sum, stakeholders reported that the discourses and practices of competition and individualism shaping education systems constitute school autonomy in ways that can create greater equity for students at some schools (through forcing individual schools to prioritize themselves) but invariably undermine equity for other schools and a collective approach to education as a public good.

Paradox 3: the discourses and practices of devolution and economic rationalism shaping the public education system constitute school autonomy in ways that disadvantage (already disadvantaged) schools

Despite the concerns raised above, there was general agreement amongst stakeholders that the flexibility afforded through school autonomy, especially around staff recruitment, could be productive for equity. Many of the stakeholders noted, however, how such flexibility disadvantaged rural and remote schools. In education systems where departmental support is decimated and responsibilities for school management are increasingly devolved, schools end up, as Delia (teacher union, Vic) commented:

... bereft of that critical advice or support that they need to deal with a whole range of equity issues. So, when you have got huge levels of complexity in your school and you have students who have got really high levels of need – whether that is ... behavioural or whether it is because they have got a disability – you know, having those structures in place is really, really

important. But, in fact, under autonomy, what's happened is: many schools are actually meant to deal with it themselves ...

One of the key ways rural/remote schools were seen to be disadvantaged, as Boris (ex-government official, NSW) pointed out, was in the area of recruitment and staffing. Edward (teacher union, NSW) spoke in this regard of the 'capacity' within devolved education systems for 'some schools to have a greater choice between good teachers than others'. As he explained:

... because out bush people are not flocking to work in [remote areas], for example; because one of the things about the local selection, you have no guarantee of coming back. People are disinclined to go or ask their family to go with them, without any assurance that they would come back.

Many of the interviewees, in recognition of this issue, viewed school autonomy as advantaging schools in privileged areas that could attract staff and students and, in turn, greater resourcing to utilize the flexibilities facilitated through autonomy. As Cedric (professional organization, Vic) commented, disadvantaged schools (e.g. in remote/rural or low SES areas) 'don't have the scale, size [and reputation] that [many] metropolitan high schools do'. For Nancy (teacher union, Vic), this scenario created a 'further equity divide' in ways that strengthened the stratification of the system and the reality that students who most needed additional support did not receive it. Nancy spoke further about this differential support in relation to the specific needs of rural/regional communities in Victoria where there were both higher needs compared to urban or suburban communities and lower local provision for 'welfare' and 'mental health' services, such as 'the capacity to employ their own student welfare teacher ... let alone social workers, psychologists'. She noted that 'devolution has not meant a flow-on of the necessary resources to enable schools to actually make those decisions about providing the supports' including for example, 'breadth of curriculum or whatever it is that they need for their students'. These concerns were also raised by Nancy in relation to small schools who 'battled to survive' within the decreasing departmental support of devolved education systems, especially given that they could not offer the range of curriculum offered by larger schools. The 'economies of scale' of the system, she argued thus, 'have much better capacity to be able to provide those services in a much more consistent and regulated way'.

Another important equity concern seen to be exacerbated by the freedoms of school autonomy reform was the differential capacity of public schools, often due to socio-geographical location, to raise funds. This differential ability for schools and communities to raise funds has dire implications for equity within systems (Rowe & Perry, 2019a). Wendy (bureaucrat, Vic) remarked upon a school in the 'eastern suburbs' of Melbourne raising 30,000, AUD easily from a fundraising event whereas a school in the 'western/southern suburbs might be lucky if they raised 2,000 AUD'. This 'capacity to leverage a community' as Kurt (bureaucrat, Vic) described it, led to great inequities in the system. Relatedly, there were also concerns raised about the differential capacity of schools to appropriately staff their school councils (Gobby & Niesche, 2019). While some school councils in privileged areas could attract, in Lionel's (parent organization, Qld) words, 'a highly competent group of people' who could not only support the school but 'stand against' the department if need be, schools in less privileged areas and especially in rural and remote areas, often found it very difficult to staff their councils.

In these areas there may be high levels of underemployment, parents may be shift workers, lack transport and time, or parents may have had bad experiences with the school system themselves as students (Blackmore & Hutchison, 2010). The inability to staff parent councils raises questions about democratic and inclusive school governance.

Some other interviewees noted the significance of principal entrepreneurialism in this space, particularly in regard to seizing opportunities to partner with philanthropic organizations to accrue extra school funding. In more autonomous school systems, especially in places such as England, these partnerships are very common and, indeed, expected by systems (Ball & Junemann, 2012; Niesche, 2010; Yoon & Winton, 2019; Yoon et al., 2019). However, there was skepticism noted about school-philanthropic partnerships as not operating within ‘equity principles’ in terms of benefiting individual schools and not the broader system (bureaucrat, Harriet, Vic). For Holly (parent organization, Vic), the ‘huge focus’ and ‘reliance’ on philanthropy was worrying because it reflected ‘public schools ... feeling the pinch’ and ‘allow[ed] the Government to shake [off] their responsibility, at Federal/State level’. Such concerns bear out in Australian research that critiques the increasing power of the philanthropic and edu-business sector to shape the governance and policy agenda of public education systems in Australia in ways that prioritize business over educative imperatives (Lingard et al., 2017).

In sum, stakeholders were in agreement that the discourses and practices of devolution and economic rationalism shaping the public education system constitute school autonomy in ways that disadvantage rural/remote, low SES and small schools (through inadequate access to quality human and material resources) thereby undermining equity for the most needy students.

Paradox 4: The discourses and practices of needs-based funding constitute school autonomy in ways that create economic injustice

The presentation of the previous areas of paradox indicates the stakeholders’ critical recognition of the discourses and practices that constitute school autonomy in ways that compromise social justice. According to most of the stakeholders, creating greater equity within and between education systems required ‘compensatory mechanisms’ (bureaucrat, Travis, Vic) and, in particular, equity funding. Many stakeholders referred to the Gonski reforms (Gonski et al., 2018, 2011) which are policy attempts to remedy the social and economic inequities of the Australian education system which have arisen since 2000. These reforms have been aimed at returning to an equity model of needs-based funding provision across all education systems in Australia that the Karmel report initiated in 1973 (Kenway, 2013). While welcoming these reforms, participants highlighted their limitations in the lack of transparency about how this funding was used to support particular groups of disadvantaged students. For instance, Kurt (bureaucrat, QLD) noted that ‘money doesn’t always go to the [areas] that the formula provides’ (i.e. Indigeneity, geographic location, school size, SES, disability). Kurt also spoke of the lack of nuance in the Gonski reforms in failing to adequately recognize the needs within rural or remote area schools:

So, you can be in a remote Indigenous school and you will get more money per head than [other] State Government school[s] but you don't get enough to fly those teachers to a regional or metropolitan capital to do regular [professional development]; and you don't get enough to fly your psychologist. So, all the reasons behind Gonski about "being able to get equity of services in those regional and remote areas" – It is not happening. – it doesn't come to fruition; because there's still not enough money in the system.

Other issues stakeholders raised in relation to resourcing were associated with the lack of support for school leaders to manage their extra responsibilities within more autonomous systems and to cope with the increasing stress levels of ever-increasing work-loads (McGrath-Champ et al., 2018; Riley, 2018). While Nancy (teacher union, Vic) noted that in Victoria there had been a recent injection of 'funds and effort to better support our school leaders' by a progressive state government, this was not always the case. She spoke of 'inadequate training' for principals in the past, as she explained:

... they were thrown into this role in the '90s. And our new principals, who are teachers, who have come through the system, who may or may not have had great levels of experience in managing a budget – in many cases, multi-million dollar budgets – and staffing, are thrown into those roles; with, I think in the past, little training and little support.

Other stakeholders highlighted problems with how school leaders used or misused their resources/funding. Charles (principal, Vic) for example, noted that 'autonomy is great if you know what you are doing' but that not all principals did, as evidenced by a recent report into the use of equity funding in NSW schools (New South Wales Auditor General, 2020). This played out, according to Uberta (bureaucrat, Vic), with some schools accruing a 'big deficit' through miscalculation of student-teacher ratios and over-employing staff. Using funds wisely, Christopher (professional organization, WA) stated, required 'capacity for schools to plan strategically for their ongoing needs, long-term'. At other schools, however, there was a reluctance to spend money. Edward (teacher union, NSW) noted, for example, that 'some principals are very, very worried about spending the money that is coming their way and ... have ... locked [it] up in school bank accounts ... because [they] are worried that it might go away'.

In sum, stakeholders noted that the discourses and practices of needs-based funding reflected a lack of transparency and nuance in distribution. When coupled with a lack of support for the administration of funding, this constitutes school autonomy in ways that create economic injustice, including in some cases, the misappropriation and misuse of funds by school leaders.

Discussion and conclusion

While the parameters of school autonomy reform have varied markedly across Australian state education systems, the official aims of this policy are consistent – that granting schools greater freedom in decision-making over matters such as finance, resourcing and staffing will lead to school and system improvement. This paper builds on the long history of research findings that counter and complicate this thesis by drawing attention to the discourses and practices of marketization constituting school autonomy in ways that compromise social justice. For the stakeholders in our research, the discourses and practices of devolution, economic efficiency, competition and individualism constitute

school autonomy in ways that have decimated structural support for public schools, exacerbated stratification and residualization within the sector, undermined a collective approach to education as a public good and disadvantaged rural/remote, low SES and small schools. These discourses and practices, as much research before us attests, continue to be paradoxical to a socially just mobilization of school autonomy in Australia as they are elsewhere (e.g. the UK, the USA, Sweden and Norway).

Compensatory mechanisms such as needs-based funding can, as we argued, go some of the way to alleviating the constitutive power of these discourses and practices to undermine social justice. However, the compensatory capacity of need-based funding is undermined when there is a lack of transparency and nuance in redistribution and a lack of administrative support for fair redistribution. Current approaches to needs-based funding in Australia, we would also argue, can do very little to alleviate the structural maldistribution embedded in our education systems produced (1) through a school funding model where nongovernment sectors (Catholic and Independent schools) are generously funded by the public purse and (2) given the vast differential capacities of schools to accrue resources from their communities and other sources (e.g. business, philanthropy and parent fundraising). Indeed, education policy at the federal level maintains such maldistribution, with any additional funds from the Gonski reforms when distributed across all three systems, guaranteeing that no school (including the already well-resourced schools in the private sector) would be worse off (Gonski et al., 2011).

The language of paradox (Dolan, 2020) reflects the enduring oppositional politics hindering redistributive justice within the Australian education context. In presenting these oppositional politics we do not presume that they are representative of all tensions between school autonomy reform and social justice. We have tried to capture the key discourses and practices arising from school autonomy located as they are within complex histories and geographies, and thus we question the dominant policy rhetoric that aligns school autonomy reform with school improvement and social justice.

We conclude by asking: How are these discourses and practices changing what is meant by the public in public education in Australia? How are they shifting ideas of public education for the public good? The argument that such discourses and practices are eroding the political claim of education as a common good (in terms of its deep tradition to support democratic participation and active informed citizenship) is well recognized in relation to the social justice issues canvassed in this paper (see Boyask, 2020; Gerrard, 2018; Smyth, 2011). What needs to be problematized is how public and private interests in education are becoming increasingly enmeshed in ways that compromise social justice. What are the consequences of the increasing infiltration of the private sector in the governance of public education (e.g. philanthropy, outsourcing of operations to the business sector) (see Lingard et al., 2017)? The business (rather than educative) imperatives driving this infiltration, as well as the uneven and differential capacities for schools to take advantage of philanthropic support, have tended to increase the systemic inequities of stratification and residualization.

In Australia, public and private interests are enmeshed with the generous public funding allocated to the private schooling sector. This allocation is clearly compromising of redistributive justice and raises important questions such as are schools in this sector public? And, if so, how should they be held more accountable to the public? The private

sector in Australia is not held to public account to the same degree as the public sector (e.g. the private sector is far more autonomous than the public sector and can deploy all manner of exclusions – on the basis of ability, class, gender and religion). This enmeshing of public and private at the very least highlights Boyask's argument (2020, p. 4):

To further public education as both ideal and practice (for the common good), we need a much more nuanced understanding of what is in the public interest, how the public is constituted and how we might define public education.

The conceptualization of public education for the common good is an ongoing project (Boyask, 2020). School autonomy reform has been positioned in policy discourse as aligned with this common good in terms of its intention to devolve decision-making and responsibility for education to schools themselves. In this sense, policy discourse has also aligned school autonomy reform with social justice. The language of paradox drawn on in this paper enables a complication of this picture in considering the discourses and practices of economic efficiency, competition and individualism constituting school autonomy in Australia that undermine social justice. In the ongoing project of re-conceptualizing public education for the public good, amid a shifting terrain between what is public about public education, critically engaging with questions arising from these areas of paradox remains imperative.

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